

Saving state in PHP

HTTTP is considered a stateless protocol. Hence, whenever you download a page from your server, it presents a separate connection. There must be some process by which information stored in one page can be accessed by subsequent pages. Here we will see some of these processes in brief.

9.1. Setting a cookie

In PHP, a cookie is set in the following ways:

setcookie() function: As the name suggests, setcookie() outputs a header and is used before sending any content to the browser. The function has certain optional and essential attributes. Cookie value, expiry date in UNIX epoch format, domain, path and integer are the optional attributes. Only the cookie name is the essential attribute of the setcookie() function.

Example:

```
<?php
$cookie_val = "We are testing cookies";
setcookie("OurCookie", $cookie_val);
setcookie("OurCookie", $cookie_val, time()+3600);
if (isset($_COOKIE['OurCookie']))
{
    echo $_COOKIE["OurCookie"];
}
?>
```

Here, either statement in line 2 or line 3 can be used to set the cookie. The value assigned to a cookie variable can also be accessed from other pages. The example given below displays the cookie created in the above example:

Example:

```
<?php
echo $_COOKIE["OurCookie"];
echo $_HTTP_COOKIE_VARS["OurCookie"];
?>
```